a shootdown." The chairman of the Joint Chiefs, General Taylor, pointed out that "existing plans call for an armed air reconnaissance and then an attack on the offending anti-aircraft site." "We are heading down the road to a choice," remarked Kennedy. "Either the IL-28s will come out and we will continue to fly high-level missions, or if the Russians refuse to withdraw the bombers, we are heading for a new showdown on Thursday or Friday."

Undersecretary of Defense Paul Nitze was all for an attack. He believed that, given the problems that the Soviets were having with the Cubans, they wanted the Americans to attack Cuban antiaircraft batteries anyway. Undersecretary of State George Ball opted for a tighter blockade of the island. He shared his impressions from attending a meeting of the NATO Council in Paris, where, according to him, there had been a "unanimous reaction that we had let the Russians off too easily and had not demanded the elimination of the Soviet base in Cuba." He added: "Our European allies would support us in finishing the job and … there would be no objection to putting pressure on the Russians again via a blockade."

But Kennedy was skeptical. He doubted that a tighter blockade was "the right response to the shooting down of a plane or the refusal to pull out the IL-28 bombers." "How can Khrushchev submit a second time?" asked the president. Paul Nitze expected the threat of force to deliver the desired result, arguing that "under Communist doctrine a Communist state can back down in the face of the superior position of an enemy." Bundy seemed to be in agreement with Nitze, indicating the need to distinguish between Soviet and Cuban targets. "We would not be acting against the Soviets by hitting Cuba," remarked the national security adviser, clearly favoring an attack.

They were back to square one, as if the fateful exchange of October 27–28 between Kennedy and Khrushchev had never taken place. As in the first days of the crisis, the president was more with the hawks than with the doves. "He asked that a statement be prepared for his use on the assumption that we have no Russian response to our IL-28 bomber withdrawal demand," reads the summary of the conversation. "We should emphasize Castro's rejection of ground inspection, thus requiring the continuance of air surveillance. We should seek to get the OAS to re-enforce our right to continue air surveillance."[2]